

SUN TANNING
Leather being put out to dry at the KLC

A GOOD PLACE TO HIDE

- **THE KOLKATA** Leather Complex has an annual turnover of Rs 15,000 crore and exports goods worth around Rs 7,500 crore
- **AT THE KLC,** 8 CETP modules can treat 40 MLD water a day
- **IT HAS** the potential to generate employment for lakhs
- **TWENTY TANNERY** owners from Uttar Pradesh are likely to expand operations here and bring in Rs 400 crore in investment
- **TOP NAMES** in UP's leather industry, like Super House, Pacific, Naaz etc., have plans to open units in Kolkata
- **KOLKATA'S** airport and port facilities are a big attraction for them

But the greatest handicap facing the KLC was the inadequate number of CETPs. For the highly polluting industry that is the leather business, they are an absolute must—actually considered as important as anything in a leather industry hub. Consequently, there were raps for allowing tanners to operate without adding to the capacity of CETPs to treat waste water. Instead of the proposed six CETP plants with a capacity to treat 30 MLD of effluents, the complex only had four CETP modules with the capacity to treat only 20 MLD.

In its first-ever environment audit in 2010-2011, the Comptroller and Auditor-General criticised the government in the strongest terms: "The project failed to achieve its stated objective of ensuring safe disposal of industrial effluents and solid waste from tanneries causing immense damage to the environment."

The gathering force of negativity around the KLC, combined with a need to generate employment and attract investment, forced the state government to act. The wheels started turning the other way around in 2015.

Bit by bit, infrastructure was improved, outstanding problems resolved. Three pumping stations with a capacity of 90,000 litres of water a day for washing leather were put in place. The matter of disposal of hazardous solid waste was also taken care of, with West Bengal Waste Management Ltd agreeing to transport 100 tonnes of waste every month to Haldia, a port city 120 kms south of Kolkata.

But the greatest difference came when four more modules of CETPs with the additional capacity to treat 20 MLD of effluent waste started operating in March 2022. While inaugurating them, Mamata said, "With eight CETPs, the only leather complex in the world to have such a capacity, KLC will attract investment worth Rs 80,000 crore and employ five lakh people."

Armed with this 40 MLD capacity, KLC is now ready to open its doors to the 187 new tanners who had already bought land in 2018 and were unable to shift because of inadequate effluent treatment capacities. Out of these tanners, around 30, among them Mukhtarul Amin, are from Kanpur and Chennai.

Now that KLC is up and running, other initiatives too are being taken up. The sludge, flesh and waste of the leather are being used for generation of electricity in a bio-gas plant as a pilot project. Along with SWITCH-Asia, a sustainable consumption and production programme, the KLC is extracting tallow oil for making tiles with 60 tonne weight-holding capacity. A secure land fill area spread over 51 acres is being prepared to store sludge and leather waste for manufacturing byproducts such as leather boards, paver tiles and sandals.

BIG NAMES IN KLC

Once their production units are up, Kanpur's tannery owners can readily benefit from the top manufacturing units that have set base in KLC. Vinit Gloves, with an annual turnover of Rs 100 crore, is a top exporter and is looking to set up a second unit. New Horizon, Trio Trends, Kompanero and ASG leather are all luxury brands with large footprints in the business and a presence in KLC.

The cost of labour—big units pay Rs 15,000-18,000 a month—too is favourable for UP's tanners. Wages of casual labourers are also cheap.

The promise of employment for 500,000-600,000 people also seems doable. According to Imran Ahmad Khan, for each crore invested in the industry, a minimum of 15 jobs are created. "This is central government statistics. So, if the new 187 tannery units are putting in an investment of Rs 4,000 crore, one can assume one lakh direct employment won't be too hard to generate," he points out.

That's a figure to be proud of. But giants from UP's leather belt—Super House, Pacific, Naaz and 15 others from Kanpur—have also taken a shine to Kolkata's leather hub. They have promised Mamata Banerjee investment worth Rs 5,000 crore. ■